Chinese from spilling into the Changchenmo Valley. The Hot Springs theatre of operations extended from the Indo-Tibetan boundary in the east to the Shyok River in the west. To the north, separated by the Karakoram I Range of mountains was the Galwan Valley, while to the south the Karakoram II Range separated it from the waters of the Pangong Tso. There were four major passes that linked the Hot Springs to the other regions—Changlung-la and Kongka-la to the north, Lanak-la in the east and the Marsmik-la to the south, which was the most frequented route into the Changchenmo Valley. The average altitude in the Hot Springs area was 14,700 feet and, unlike the Galwan Valley, the gradient towards the Changchenmo River was wide and gentle. Only towards the western exit of the sector did the valley narrow sharply, after which the Changchenmo flowed into the Shyok River.

The Tsogstsalu post was the closest to Marsmik-la, and it came under harassing fire on 23 October. Both HQ 3 Division and 114 Brigade, when informed, presumed that it would be a matter of time before the Chinese cut off Hot Springs from the south. Raina therefore suggested to Major Ajit Singh that he leave a small party behind and withdraw over the Marsmik-la to the 5 Jat Battalion HQ at Phobrang. Ajit Singh was vehemently opposed to any withdrawal, firm in the belief that the defences at Hot Springs could be held. Besides, he further argued, if he had to abandon Hot Springs, he would much rather move downstream along the Changchenmo and link up with Randhawa's men pulling back from DBO and the Galwan Sector.

Ultimately, it was Raina's call, and the brigade commander had to weigh his options carefully. The southern slopes of the Marsmik-la were defended by the Kongma and Kongma I posts, which were the last positions held by a platoon from Delta Company of 5 Jat commanded by Subedar Surjit Singh. Geographically, the Kongma tract that embraced the southeastern slope of the Marsmik Massif was a part of the Pangong-Spanggur region. The Kongma positions were opposite Anne-la where three Chinese pickets marked their claim line. A motorable road connected the pass with the Chinese rear HQ at Dambu Guru.

The Chinese had engaged the two Kongma positions on 22 October. As the bombardment began at 2 p.m., Surjit Singh ordered the men from Kongma I to fall back on the main post. Owing to the intensity of mortar and machine gun fire, the withdrawing section had to go to ground amidst the rocks. Despite being hopelessly outnumbered, the Jats doggedly held on